

Praja RAAG
(Research Analysis &
Advocacy Group)



COMMUTER RAIL SERVICE BANGALORE

Objective

Make commuter rail an additional mass transport option to connect the people of Bangalore & its suburbs

Scope

Raise awareness amongst citizens to the benefits of commuter rail & advocate the case with the government so they can make it happen

About Praja RAAG

"praja.in" (PRAJA, for short) is an e-platform of over 8,000 (registered) citizens, largely 'techies' of Bangalore, engaging in informed debates over various civic issues, and thereafter arriving at solutions (where possible, some of the solutions are then pursued on ground through **PRAJA-RAAG** - research, analysis, advocacy group). We call PRAJA a virtual hall for debates. Over the years, it has become clear that many senior level bureaucrats are looking into PRAJA on a regular basis. PRAJA as such has no specific opinion on any subject; it is just a platform for debates. Anybody is welcome to join it, and put his/ her blogs/ comments. The moderation is only in the case of inflammatory writings, judged by a panel of editors, if users report abuse. There are no dominant voices; there are only more prolific bloggers, less prolific bloggers, the odd commentators, and the browsers. RAAG (which is proposed to be registered as a trust) will be the owner and supporter of PRAJA, though, any set of **Prajagalu** can independently pursue any given project, even without the direct involvement of a RAAG member.

Praja RAAG & Commuter Rail

Praja RAAG believes in "Solutionism" as a means to solve problems facing citizens. It encourages citizens to discuss & debate solutions to problems & take it up with support from anybody else who may be interested in the issue. One such issue that cropped up in 2009 was usage of existing railway tracks for commuting to work, considering the roads were choked & private vehicles only worsened it. After a lot of discussion Commuter Rail (branded as NammaRailu) was taken up for research & advocacy.

The Commuter Rail

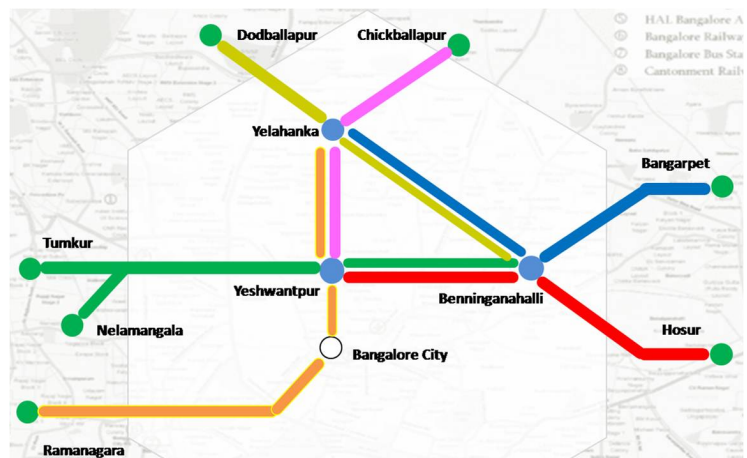
Provisioning mass transport for the growing economy has become a priority. With the kind of visibility Bengaluru has in the international arena and the role India is going to play in the world of the future, it is important for both central and state governments to sit up and take notice. Ignoring the long-term mass transport needs of the city can backfire on the country. The economy of any city thrives on availability of good quality labor at

affordable cost. Expensive housing and increased travel times only put more pressure on productivity of human capital. This may ultimately lead to flight of capital and hurt the economy with cascading effect.

Housing has already become unaffordable in Bengaluru for the lower and middle classes, which is going to form a major portion of the workforce of the future. The industrial areas around Bengaluru lie close to the existing Indian Railways tracks and are being wasted as a viable mass transit option. No amount of connectivity within the city will be successful if that connectivity is not supplemented by mass transit to these industrial clusters. The key is frequent, low cost connectivity, which can be achieved by utilizing and enhancing the existing train tracks between Bengaluru and these growth centers. Multiple reports over 27 years including RITES surveys have confirmed this fact.

This Commuter Rail Service for Bengaluru on the lines of MRVC, Mumbai & MMTS, Hyderabad will require the following

1. Setting up a Special Purpose Vehicle between representative entities of the Indian Railways and the Government of Karnataka, possibly executed on PPP basis
2. Introduce new trains on new routes and increase the frequency on all routes
3. Increase capacity of tracks and implement state of the art signaling systems
4. Build new stations with good quality infrastructure and improve accessibility to existing stations with last mile connectivity
5. Create multimodal hubs and interchanges to allow people to change to other modes of transport



The benefits of the Commuter Rail Service is multifold

1. At least 50 lakh people and multiple Industrial areas can be covered by existing 200+ kms of railway tracks
2. Availability of labor for growth of the already established economic ecosystem
3. Decongestion of the city & increased efficiency in commute times
4. Affordable housing for lower & middle classes
5. Significantly lower capital expenditure on provisioning mass transit by sharing Railway infrastructure

The Call to Action report prepared by Praja.in in conjunction with CiSTUP provides a citizens perspective of a quickly implementable, viable alternative. The report lays out the need and urgency of running full fledged commuter trains under a dedicated SPV set up for this purpose.

Achievements

1. Call to action report with support from CiSTUP was released in June 2010, which tabulated the full history & benefits of commuter rail. Branded NammaRailu, this report laid the foundation for the commuter rail campaign
2. Released the report in Mobilicity 2010 under the aegis of CiSTUP & presented to DULT, GoK who accepted to take up the project further
3. Participated in presentations & awareness discussions with various government stakeholders like DULT, IDD, Chief Secretary, SWR & industry bodies like BCIC. Since the project involved center state coordination it was all the more challenging for Praja to get all the stakeholders in the same plane.
4. Multiple representations were made to local leaders, MP's, MLA's & Union Ministers. Report was also presented to Railway entities like the Railway board members, SWR representatives etc. This was a sustained campaign lasting many months
5. After sustained follow-up DPR was commissioned with RITES by DULT for the implementation of commuter rail & Involved Praja RAAG in technical discussions pertaining to the same. The RITES report was also shared with Praja RAAG for sharing with the public
6. Continued citizens awareness sessions by Praja RAAG in conjunction with various institutions like IISc & citizen representatives like Hasiru Usiru, Citizens Action Forum, OneBengaluru etc. This included mailer campaigns which users & citizens could send to their representatives to ask for commuter rail
7. RITES report has been released & accepted by DULT/IDD. This is a milestone like no other & as SWR's DRM Sudhanshu Mani mentioned to Praja, this was one of the best & most acceptable reports on Commuter Rail for Bengaluru so far in the history of commuter rail reports that have been churned out by all & sundry. This was no mean achievement considering every effort so far never had Railways & GoK agreeing to go forward on any terms of any report.

Next Steps

1. Praja RAAG is working with other organizations like ORRCA to organize train day on the lines of bus day to make the use of suburban trains more popular for daily commuting needs
2. Praja RAAG will continue to educate & inform citizens of the benefits of commuter rail
3. Praja RAAG will continue to work towards making cheaper mass transport alternatives like commuter rail an option for a large section of suburban community which form a key cog in the economic & social wheel
4. Government will soon be commissioning an SPV to take forward the commuter rail for Bangalore. A golden chance that cannot be missed considering this is the closest anyone has gotten to getting all central & state stakeholders in the same place for a massive project like this

References

<http://praja.in/nammarailu>

(All details including evidence of activities & documents is available at the above URL)